
An Ambassador of Saffron: A Character Sketch on Yogi Adithyanath.

- *By Gaurika Rashmi Nair*

This man strolls into the committee hall as if he has already won, and it is a matter of interpretation as to whether this is a symptom of overconfidence or complete misunderstanding of the dynamics at play. This man, dressed in saffron reds & oranges, wearing Indian clothes, is clearly sending some signals here.

He is a study in contradictions. Externally he is loud and confident, the kind of person who speaks before other people can think. Internally, he is meticulous and organized; when you see him prepare for debates in the committee; he is carefully noting down inconsistencies and reading up on every rule and procedure involved to score the points he needs. He is a man of discipline and order who does not want to listen to anyone else but himself.

He has come into the debate with clear and established views, which he is determined to stick to regardless of facts and figures. He does not believe in any western propaganda, although there is a possibility that this principle does not apply to his debating style. All the delegates in the committee are sanatanis, one unified family, he says, until the trans rights motion is proposed and suddenly the family has a guest list. Marriage is only possible between men and women, sacred and eternal; that is the kind of statement you make when you know nothing of its roots.

He is dismissive of facts in a particular and predictable way. He believes that since male sexual assault numbers are low, the problem must be smaller too; he does not care about the boy who has been taught to regard reporting such acts as unmanly, and therefore chooses not to do it. He

believes that the absence of data means absence of pain, either out of sheer ignorance or for purely practical purposes, after all he is a politician.

He is, in the very end, less a delegate than a mirror, one held up to a very specific kind of politics that has learned to speak the language of unity while practicing the arithmetic method of exclusion. He will tell you he stands for everyone, right before explaining, patiently, who doesn't count. That is the trick, and it is not a new one. Dress the old hierarchies in new metaphors, call exclusion tradition, call silence strength, call control a vow. But when committees end, motions get passed or shot down, and somewhere outside this room the people he keeps footnoting out of his speeches are still waiting for the provisions he had promised them. Saffron looks good under committee lighting. It does not, however, look particularly good on a man who has confused certainty for conviction.
